SLSO’s experiences with Patient recruitment

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Coordinating **Feasibility Sweden- Region Stockholm Gotland**

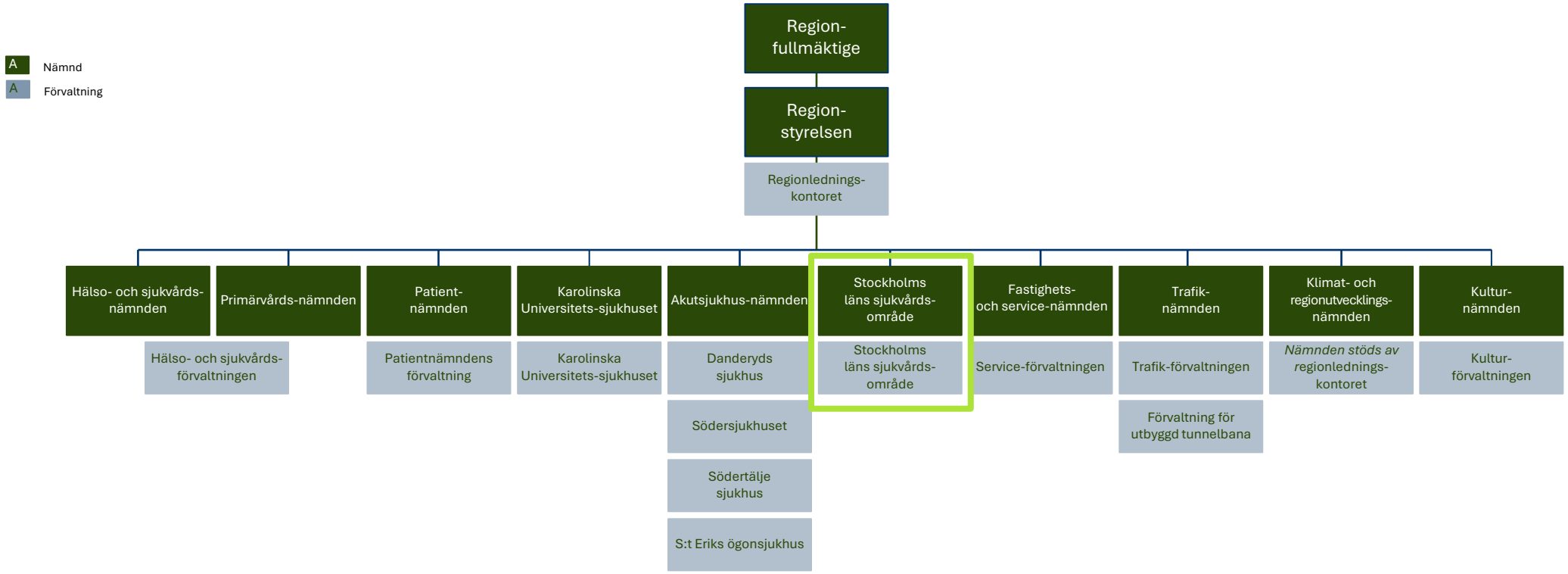
Region Stockholm

Agenda

- Organization of Stockholm county Healthcare Services (SLSO)
- Examples of research support
  - Unit for Research and Innovation support , Academic Primary Healthcare Center (APC), SLSO
  - Study Unit, SLSO
- Patient Recruitment in Clinical Studies
  - Challenges
  - Support
  - The future
- Questions

Region Stockholm

SLSO within Region Stockholm



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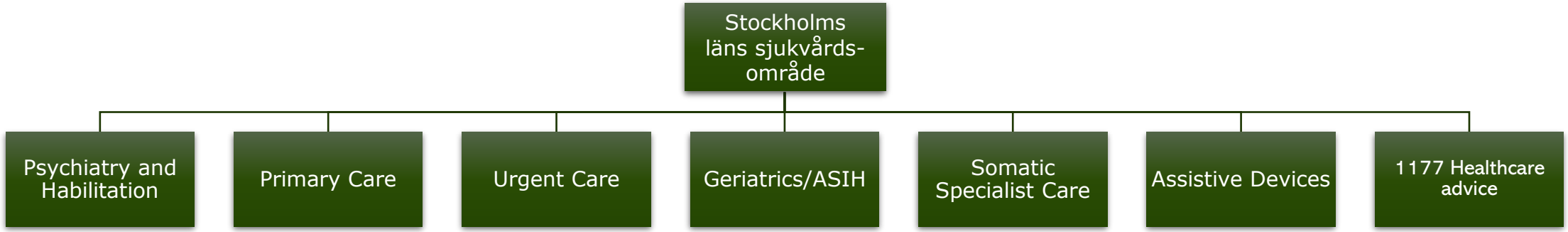
SLSO’s organisation



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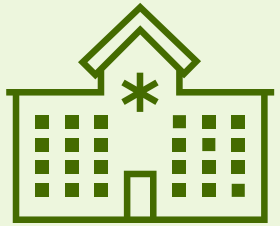
Two examples of SLSO research support structures

Unit for Research and Innovation support, APC, SLSO



Study Unit, SLSO

Region Stockholm

Unit for Research and Innovation support in Primary care, APC

Support to Researchers & Principal Investigators in primary care

Administrative research support:

Budget/agreements questions, research funding administration

Cooperation with Karolinska Institute – Research networks to strengthen primary care researcher

Counseling – research administration clinical studies

Administrative support to primary care units that want to participate in clinical studies

Start up support (budget/agreements)

Recruitment strategies

Coordinate opinion from Committee for research feasibilities

Clinical study support to Researchers & Principal investigators

(full cost coverage needed)

Study start-up

Research coordination in primary care

Patient recruitment

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Study Unit SLSO - for researchers within all of Region Stockholm

Facility and staff for complete clinical studies

- Conducts clinical studies from feasibility to close-out
- Established SOP:s and routines
- Facilities designed for clinical studies
- All staff trained in GCP etc.

Administrative support

- Start-up support (budget/agreements/logistics)
- Recruitment strategies
- Project management/mentoring during study

Selective measures

- Temporary staff support for specific study
- Recruitment assistance
- Part of study such as blood sampling etc.

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Examples of how SLSO can support in clinical studies

- Feasibility Coordination
- Infrastructure and operational support
- Patient recruitment
- Efficient Start Up Processes
- Collaboration within Region

Region Stockholm

Examples of how SLSO can support in clinical studies

- **Feasibility Coordination**
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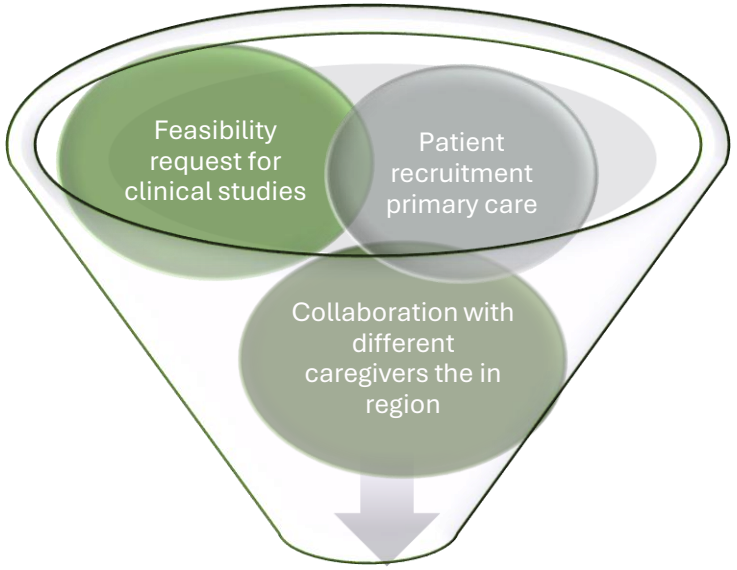
Feasibility Coordination



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Stockholms läns sjukvårds-område

- Psychiatry and Habilitation
- Primary Care
- Urgent Care
- Geriatrics/ASIH
- Somatic Specialist Care
- Assistive Devices
- 1177 Healthcare advice

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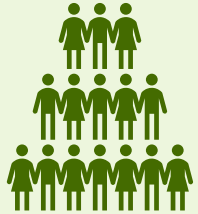
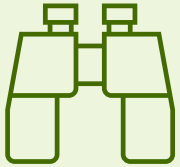
Patient recruitment



Challenges in patient recruitment

Examples of Recruitment tools



Future

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Patient recruitment

Challenges in patient recruitment

Examples of Recruitment tools

Future

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Challenges in patient recruitment for clinical studies

General challenges

Patient- Related Factors

Healthcare and Organizational Factors

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Challenges in patient recruitment for clinical studies

General challenges

Patient- Related Factors

Healthcare and Organizational Factors

- Limited access to eligible patients
- Competition for same patients
  - Multiple parallel studies/trials within the same disease area
- Time consuming recruitment -> Delays
  - Leads to increased costs and risk of underpowered studies

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Challenges in patient recruitment for clinical studies

General challenges

Patient- Related Factors

Healthcare and Organizational Factors

- Laws/regulations does not make it easy...
- Low patient awareness and understanding
  - Unclear communication about studies, purpose and potential benefits
- Patient burden
  - Additional visits, procedures and time commitment

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Challenges in patient recruitment for clinical studies

General challenges

Patient- Related Factors

Healthcare and Organizational Factors

- Limited time in clincal practice
  - Healthcare professional need to prioritize routine care over research
- Lack of incentives and support
  - Insufficient resources for research nurses and study coordinators

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What can you as a researcher do?

Study design and Feasibility

- Simplify protocols where possible: both inclusion/exclusion criteria, logistic, and patient visits
- Design patient centric studies
  - Align schedule and endpoints with routine care where possible
- Conduct realistic feasibility assessment (population calculation)
- Engage primary care early in design phase

Patient Engagement & Communication

- Improve patient facing material/information
  - Use clear non-technical language
  - Explain benefits and risks transparently
- Engage patients early
  - Involve patient representative/patient groups during study design phase

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What can you as a researcher do?

Clinical site & staff support

- Time for research
  - Ensure you have funding to cover time for site staff to conduct the study
  - Ensure that clinic's management is informed about and engaged in the study
- Use the available research infrastructure in the region
  - Include budget for this type of support when you write your funding application

Recruitment Strategies

- Broaden recruitment pathways at the planning phase
  - Make plan A, B, C, include all variations in the EPM application
- Use digital tools where suitable
  - For example, pre-screening and remote visits where possible

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Patient recruitment

Challenges in patient recruitment

Examples of Recruitment tools

Future

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Patients' opportunity to participate in clinical studies - Recruitment tools in clinical studies

Population calculations

Targeted information

Clinical Decision Support Tool

Advertising/information about studies

SLSO study unit's participant database

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Patients' opportunity to participate in clinical studies - Recruitment tools in clinical studies

Population calculations

Targeted information

Clinical Decision Support Tool

Advertising/information about studies

SLSO study unit's participant database

- Search criteria are defined based on inclusion/exclusion criteria, to determine if the patient population exist within primary care
- SLSO's unit for analysis performs the population calculation
- Results are presented as number of patients per care unit who fullfills the criteria

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Patients' opportunity to participate in clinical studies - Recruitment tools in clinical studies

Population calculations

Targeted information

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Advertising/information about studies

SLSO study unit's participant database

SLSO process of recruitment with targeted information

1. Head of Clinic uses a digital search tool (Medrave) to determine if they have the patient population based on inclusion and exclusion criteria
2. Head of Clinic share information about study with their patients – via Alltid Öppet
3. Patient approves in Alltid Öppet that their contact details will be shared with study staff
4. Study staff can then contact and pre-screen the patient and for the study

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Patients' opportunity to participate in clinical studies - Recruitment tools in clinical studies

Population calculations

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Clinical decision support tool, i e ALMA, can be used to promote recruitment:

1. An algorithm is created based on inclusion and exclusion criteria
2. The algorithm is only active when healthcare staff opens the patient's medical records in during patient contact
3. Healthcare staff will be alerted if the patient fulfills the criteria for the study
4. The patient is asked if they are interested, and if so, if they approve to be contacted by the study team

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Patients' opportunity to participate in clinical studies - Recruitment tools in clinical studies

Population calculations

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Advertising/information about studies

SLSO study unit's participant database

Types of advertisements vary depending on target population

- Social media
- Newspapers- suitable for older population
- In healthcare facilities – posters, digital screens, flyers etc.
- During patient visits: verbal information by healthcare professional
- Clinic website and general websites such as Accindi etc.

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Patients' opportunity to participate in clinical studies - Recruitment tools in clinical studies

Population calculations

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SLSO study unit's participant database

SLSO's database for possible participants

- For studies conducted at the study unit
- Anyone can register through Alltid Öppet
- Age and diagnosis shared at registration
- Can be filtered based on age, sex and diagnosis
- Updated against the national population registry (Folkbokföringsregistret)

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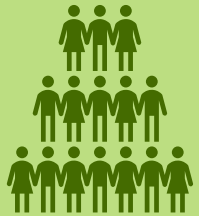
Patient recruitment



Challenges in patient recruitment

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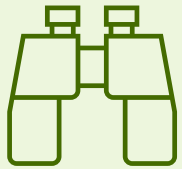

Future

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Possibilities for the future

- National /regional processes that enables more effective recruitment
  - National therapy networks enabling patient recruitment
  - New electronical medical records system in Region Stockholm
  - Centralisation of clinical IT (Vårdens IT)
- Feasibility calculations to be done on a regional level
- Updated GDPR?

Take home messages

Include several recruitment strategies in your application. Engage primary care early

Population calculation when needed during feasibility phase

Early engagement of clinical management

Use digital tools wisely, risk for alert fatigue...

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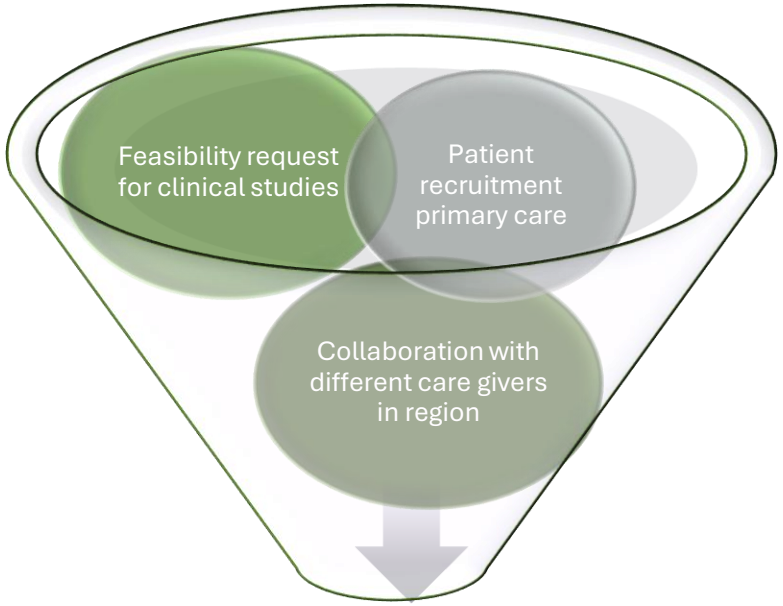
Do you need support / have questions about research in SLSO?



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Questions?

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THANK YOU!

Contact information: studieforfragningar.slso@regionstockholm.se

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